

BRONZED The 108 ft tall statue of Bengaluru city founder Nadaprabhu Kempegowda at the international airport



"THE SOLUTION IS NOT TO TAKE BACK POWER FROM LOCAL SELF-GOVERNMENT AND GIVE IT TO THE STATE GOVERNMENT. THIS IS A VIOLATION OF THE 74TH AMENDMENT"

KATHYAYINI CHAMARAJ, Executive trustee, CIVIC Bangalore

drew criticism because of bloopers such as the mention of Maharashtra towns Malegaon and Nashik in the traffic volume analyses for Bengaluru, prompting the BBMP to slap a Rs 5 lakh fine on the consultant that prepared the report.

"Eight years since the steel flyover protests, it is unfortunate that we are still discussing projects we don't want," says Prof. Ashish Verma, who heads the Sustainable Transportation Laboratory at the Bengaluru-based Indian Institute of Science (IISc). Concurs Satya Arikutharam, an independent mobility expert who worked on the Bengaluru Metropolitan Land Transport Authority (BMLTA) Bill while previously serving as chief technical advisor to the Directorate of Urban Land Transport. "The city has to take a decision. Are you going to spend Rs 20,000 crore only for car users or are you going spend it on public transport?" he asks. "This is where the city misses the institutional capability of BMLTA."

Conceived as a unified planning authority for every form of transport within the city, BMLTA was enacted in 2022 but exists only on paper. Prof. Verma says the BMLTA should be operationalised immediately for a 'holistic vision for the city' in how transport is governed. Currently, the share of public transport (via buses and metro) in Bengaluru is just under 50 per cent. "We should be at 80 per cent at least, along with walking and cycling," says Verma, who published a traffic simulation study in December 2024. It showed that the share of public transport would go down with the tunnel roads and double-decker flyovers as they encourage private vehicles. The government should instead complete the metro rail and BSRP corridors on a war footing, prioritising the construction of sections with high demand forecasts, he suggests.

THE CHALLENGES

"We are not looking at today, we are planning for 30-40 years from now," Shivakumar said at a press conference in February, adding that, "whatever you do, you cannot survive without criticism. Criticism is a part of life." The deputy CM's argument is that creating new roads overground would be financially unviable given the skyrocketing real estate market in the city. As an example, he points out that the long-pending 73 km peripheral ring road project which would have cost Rs 2,000-3,000 crore had it been constructed in 2006-07 when originally proposed, has now escalated to Rs 26,000 crore.

Bengaluru's track record in infrastructure projects has also been poor, says R.K. Misra, a member of the citizen's group Bengaluru Political Action Committee (BPAC). A case in point, he says, is the infamous Ejipura flyover, which remains incomplete even eight years after work began. This 2.5 km elevated road passes over Koramangala, one of the city's most expensive localities. Now, the BBMP has proposed a special purpose vehicle (SPV) comprising town planners, engineers and administrators to execute big infrastructure projects, which Misra says is a welcome move. "Bengaluru needs many different solutions," he adds. On the drawing board are ambitious plans, and, equally, concerns about their viability. The tech city is at a crossroads. ■

BENGALURU'S OTHER WOES

LACK OF COORDINATION While Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike (BBMP) is the civic body that administers the city, crucial amenities are provided by six other parastatals, including Bangalore Development Authority (BDA) and Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board (BWSSB)

GROUNDWATER DRYING UP New localities depend on borewells, leading to severe summer water shortages. The BWSSB has ramped up supply of Cauvery water, targeting 400,000 new connections in borewell-dependent areas

STORMWATER DRAINS The city has 800 km of stormwater drains but the clogged network causes frequent flooding during rains. A Rs 5,000 crore disaster mitigation plan, part-funded by the World Bank, is underway

LEGACY WASTE The city has 9.8 million tonnes of accumulated legacy waste. Initiatives on to process this in phases via bio-mining and bio-remediation